

GA-HR-10

# Theft, Suspected Theft & Protection of Property

Standards for protecting school and personal property, reporting concerns, preserving evidence, and responding through a fair process.

## APPLIES TO

Gardner Academy employees and relevant staff

## AUTHORITY

Gardner Academy workplace conduct and property-protection standard

### 01 Purpose and standard

Every employee must respect property belonging to the school, students, families, colleagues, contractors, and visitors. Theft, attempted theft, fraud, deliberate unauthorised use, concealment, or knowingly receiving stolen property is prohibited. Staff must report concerns privately and must not treat an allegation as proof.

### 02 What must not be taken or misused

Without proper permission, staff must not:

- Take, remove, hide, keep, sell, give away, or dispose of money, food, supplies, equipment, records, devices, keys, learning materials, lost property, or personal belongings.
- Use school funds, accounts, purchasing processes, stock, vehicles, equipment, data, or services for personal benefit.
- Alter receipts, inventories, attendance information, payment records, or other documents to obtain a benefit or conceal a loss.
- Ask or encourage a student or colleague to remove, hide, or obtain property on their behalf.
- Keep found property instead of submitting it through the school lost-property or management process.

### 03 Everyday protection of property

Employees must use school property only for authorised work, follow sign-out and stock-control procedures, secure cash, keys, devices, records, and valuable materials, and report missing or damaged items promptly. Personal valuables should be kept in the designated secure area where one is available.

## **04 Reporting suspected theft**

A person who discovers a loss or has a reasonable concern should promptly report it privately to the Principal, Operations, or another designated manager. Record only relevant facts, including what is missing, when and where it was last seen, who had authorised access, and any records or witnesses that may assist. Do not accuse a person publicly, circulate names or rumours, confront a suspected person, or attempt a private investigation.

## **05 Preserving evidence**

Staff must not alter, delete, photograph for personal use, share, hide, or remove possible evidence. Employees must follow instructions to protect an area, item, record, or device and must give relevant information only to the authorised person handling the report. CCTV, access records, financial records, and device information may be accessed only by an employee whose role and authorisation permit it.

## **06 Searches and personal dignity**

No employee may personally search another person, their clothing, bag, phone, vehicle, locker, or belongings. Any inspection or search must be authorised by management, have a lawful and reasonable basis, respect privacy and dignity, and follow the applicable school procedure. A student-related concern must also follow safeguarding requirements. Police or another appropriate authority should be involved where required.

## **07 During an investigation**

Employees must cooperate honestly, maintain confidentiality, preserve evidence, avoid rumours or accusations, and give the person handling the matter any relevant records or explanation requested through the authorised process. Retaliation against a person who raises a genuine concern or participates honestly is prohibited. Deliberately false or malicious allegations may be treated as misconduct.

## **08 Recovery, reporting, and disciplinary action**

Staff must not demand repayment, arrange private compensation, deduct money, contact an insurer or police on behalf of the school, or negotiate a settlement unless specifically authorised. Returning property or repaying a loss does not automatically resolve a misconduct concern. Proven theft, fraud, or dishonesty may constitute serious misconduct and may lead to disciplinary action under the applicable process.

## **09 Property found in school**

Found money or property must be handed promptly to Administration or the designated responsible person and recorded where required. It must be stored securely while reasonable efforts are made to identify the owner. Unclaimed property may be managed only through an approved school decision; it does not become the property of the person who found it.